**M.R. SHARAN**
https://mrsharan.com
sharan@umd.edu

## Employment

**Assistant Professor, University of Maryland** Jan 2021-

Post-Doctoral Fellow, Center for Global Development July 2020 - Dec 2020
Research Associate, JPAL South Asia June 2012 – October 2013
Research Assistant, International Growth Center April 2011 – April 2012

## Education

PhD, Harvard University 2014-2020

**Thesis Title: *"Essays in Development Economics and Political Economy"***

M. A., Delhi School of Economics 2009-2011
B. A. (Hons), Hans Raj College, Delhi University 2006-2009

## Classes Taught

AREC 869: Political Economy of Development
AREC 365: World Hunger, Population and Food Supplies
AREC 370: From Poverty to Progress: India's Political Economy in Transition

## Published Research Papers

*"Women Political Leaders, Corruption, and Learning: Evidence from a Large Public Program in India"* (with Farzana Afridi and Vegard Iversen, *Economic Development and Cultural Change*, *66*(1), pp.1-30.)

*"Learning to Govern: The Impact of Politicians' Peer Networks"* (with Apurva Bamezai, Siddharth George, Siddharth Hari and Munish Sharma, *Accepted under the Phase-1 Pre-Results Track at the Journal of Development Economics*

*"The Short- and Long-Run Distributional Consequences of Political Reservations"* (with Chinmaya Kumar, *Conditionally Accepted* at the *Journal of the European Economic Association*)

## Book Chapter

*Two Hundred and Fifty Thousand Democracies: A Review of Panchayati Raj in India* (with Siddharth George and Vijayendra Rao), *Forthcoming* at the *Cambridge Companion to Indian Politics and Society*

## Working Papers

*"Do Elected Leaders Add Value? Evidence from a Natural Experiment in India"* (with Abhishek Arora, Siddharth George, Nivedita Mantha and Vijayendra Rao)
**Submitted**

*"The Impact of Women's Self Help Groups on Political Entry: Evidence from India"* (with Iman Sen)
**Revise and Resubmit, Economic Journal**

*"The Determinants and Consequences of Political Selection in the Developing World: Evidence from India"* (with Apurva Bamezai, Siddharth George and Borui Sun)

*"Complaint Resolution Systems and Local Governance: Experimental Evidence from Rural India"* (with Chinmaya Kumar)
**Under revision**

*"Safe Spaces or Elite Networks? Experimental Evidence on What Empowers Disadvantaged Groups"* (with Apurva Bamezai, Siddharth George, Siddharth Hari and Munish Sharma)

*"Does the Graduation Program Scale? Evidence from India"* (with Abhijit Banerjee, Esther Duflo, Andrés Orduña Correcher, Jyoti Mukhopadhyay and Shagun Sabarwal)

*"Collective Action and Public Service Delivery: Experimental Evidence from a Social Movement in India"* (with Niharika Singh)

*"Who, Not How Many: Local Council Design and Workfare Delivery in Rural India"* (with Siddharth George and Nandini Gupta)

**Papers in Preparation**

*"Affirmative Action, Attitudes and Social Networks: Evidence from Caste-Based Reservation in India"* (with Emily Breza and Arun Chandrasekhar)

*"Local Taxation and Development Outcomes"* (with Abhishek Arora, Siddharth George, Vijayendra Rao)

**Other Research Papers**

*Making the Bihar Caste Census Better,* The India Forum, April 2023

*Dispute Resolution mechanisms in Bihar* (with Sabyasachi Das), Seminar, Feb 2023

"*The National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme in Rajasthan: Rationed Funds and their allocation across villages*" (with Himanshu and Abhiroop Mukhopadhyay), Economic and Political Weekly, 2015

"*Identifying BPL Households: A Comparison of Competing Approaches*", Economic and Political Weekly, 2011, pp.256-262

**Public Writings**

*Bihar's unrealised potential, The Hindu, Dec 2025 (with Munish Sharma)*

*Bihari Mukhiyas: Handy & Held Back, Times of India, Nov 2025*

*Bihar's got bijli, sadak and pani now, but it's still missing foundation for prosperity, Indian Express, Oct 2025*

*Census that has to be more than a headcount, The Hindustan Times, Jul 2025*

*India needs a new decentralisation—let politicians manage people, experts handle policies, ThePrint, Sep 2024 (with Abhishek Arora, Siddharth George, Nivedita Mantha and Vijayendra Rao)*

*Nitish Kumar's survey and history of caste churn in Bihar, Indian Express, Oct 2023*

*Caste data's benefits and risks may be overblown, Hindustan Times, Aug 2023*
*Why we need the Bihar caste census* (with M V Swaroop), July 2023

*What we don't understand about prohibition in Bihar: It's popular,* Dec 2022

*Accurate Caste Data Can Propel Progress,* Hindustan Times, July 2022

*What the Bihar Model Got Right and Where it Missed the Mark,* Times of India, Nov 2020.

*How Caste Equations Continue to Shape Bihar's Economic Fortunes*, Outlook, December 2021.

*The particulars of social policy in India: Evidence, State capacity, and policy design* (with Apurva Bamezai), Ideas for India, Sep 2018

*Secular Hymns, Economic and Political Weekly, Vol. 53, Issue No. 47, 01 Dec, 2018*

*Remembering and Forgetting in Bihar, Economic and Political Weekly, Vol. 53, Issue No. 39, 29 Sep, 2018.*

**Book**

*Last Among Equals: Power, Caste and Politics in Bihar's Villages,* Context, 2021.

**Novel**

*Blue*, HarperCollins, 2014.

**Grants and Fellowships:**

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| 2025-26 | Gates Foundation Bridge Grant | $20,000 |
| 2025-26 | Notre Dame University Kellogg Institute<br>(with Niharika Singh [University of Notre Dame]) | $20,000 |
| 2024-25 | ISLA Large Research Grant<br>(with Niharika Singh [University of Notre Dame]) | $20,000 |
| 2024-25 | BIG Lab's Mezzanine Grant Award<br>(with Niharika Singh [University of Notre Dame]) | $40,000 |
| 2024-25 | World Bank Research Funding<br>(with Siddharth George [NUS, Singapore] and Vijayendra Rao [World Bank]) | $50,000 |
| 2023-24 | Ford Program Faculty Research Award (with Niharika Singh [UND]) | $25,000 |
| 2023-24 | The International Growth Centre<br>(with Apurva Bamezai [UPenn], Siddharth George [NUS], Siddharth Hari [World Bank]) | $82,000 |
| 2023-24 | Gates Foundation | $250,000 |
| 2022-23 | J-PAL Governance Initiative | $75,000 |
| 2022-23 | J-PAL Governance Initiative | $169,510 |
| 2022-23 | INCITE Grant<br>(with Niharika Singh [UND]) | $19,600 |
| 2022-23 | Weiss Fund<br>(with Apurva Bamezai [UPenn], Siddharth George [NUS], Siddharth Hari [World Bank]) | $93,427 |
| 2022-23 | World Bank Research Funding<br>(with Siddharth George [NUS, Singapore] and Vijayendra Rao [World Bank]) | $100,000 |
| 2021-22 | UPIASI CSR Funding<br>(with Apurva Bamezai (UPenn), Aashish Gupta (Harvard) and Harsha Thirumurthy (UPenn) | INR 4000000 |

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| 2021-22 | Georgetown University Small Grant<br>(with Rajesh Veeraraghavan [Georgetown] and Iman Sen [University of Maryland]) | $21,000 |
| 2021-22 | Marshall Foundation Grant | $21,050 |
| 2021-22 | World Bank Research Funding<br>(with Siddharth George [NUS, Singapore] and Vijayendra Rao [World Bank]) | $180,000 |
| 2020-21 | The Weiss Fund (IPG 2020) | $22,000 |
| 2019-20 | Warburg Fellowship<br>(with Emily Breza [Harvard] and Arun Chandrasekhar [Stanford]) | $7,500 |
| 2018-19 | The Weiss Fund (with Chinmaya Kumar [University of Chicago]) | $31,385 |
| 2018-20 | The Weiss Fund (with Emily Breza [Harvard] and Arun Chandrasekhar [Stanford]) | $69,810 |
| 2018-20 | Rockefeller Grant for Technology and Governance<br>(through the IDFC Institute, Mumbai) | $300,000 |
| 2015-16 | JPAL GI Travel/Proposal Grant | $4,500 |
| 2014-15 | GSAS Fellowship in honor of Amartya Sen | |

**Research Experience during PhD:**

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| 2018-19 | IDFC Institute, Senior Research Associate |
| 2016-17 | Economist, Office of the Chief Economic Adviser, Ministry of Finance, Government of India |

**Professional Activities**

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| Referee | *American Economic Review, Journal of Political Economy, American Economic Journal: Applied, American Economic Review: Insights, American Economic Journal: Policy, Review of Economics and Statistics, Journal of Human Resources, Journal of Development Economics, Journal of Economic Growth, Journal of Economic Behavior and Organization, Journal of Public Economics, Economic Development and Culture Change, Journal of Politics, Journal of Development Studies* |
| Seminars/Conference Talks | *BREAD (Zurich, 2026), BREAD (Stanford, 2026), Indian Statistical Institute (2025), NEUDC (Tufts University, 2025). American University Seminar Series (2025), NLSIU Bangalore (2025), SNU Mahabalipuram (2025); IIM Bangalore (2025), IIT Delhi (2025), Azim Premji University (2024/25), National University of Singapore (2024), Georgetown University Economics Seminar Series (2024), World Bank DEC Seminar (2024)*, NEUDC (*Tufts 2025. Harvard University 2023, Northwestern 2019), MWIEDC (University of Chicago 2024), UCSD India Seminar Series (2023), Indian Statistical Institute (2023), Delhi School of Economics (2023), Paris School of Economics (2023), Ashoka University (2022), Centre de Sciences Humaines (2022)*, *IFPRI (2022), John's Hopkins SAIS (2022), NEUDC (2019), ISI Delhi Conference (2018, 2019, 2021), The Lakshmi Mittal and Family South Asia Institute (Harvard)* |
| Media Appearances | *Ideas of India podcast, Mercatus Center (2025), NDTV India, Scroll.in, Newslaundry* |

**Languages**

English, Kannada, Tamil, Telugu, Hindi